

WORKSHOP: FROM IDIOT BOX TO SMART TV

Idiot box too dumb for you? Here's a workshop that'll help transform your TV from dumb to smart in no time at all.

Anirudh Regidi

The first part of this story would have given you a primer with regards to why your TV is dumb and the second part showed you what you can do to finally cut the cord. Now we'll tell you how to smarten up your idiot box and don't worry, it's actually not that hard.

The TV in this situation is just a screen, it's a mindless output device that is just displaying content that it receives. Our goal here is to transform that content and make our TV viewing experience an intelligent, interactive and pleasurable one.

We do that by giving our TV access to the sources of entertainment that we want and have it presented to us in a fashion that we would enjoy.

Initial Setup Setting up a VPN

This is an important step because many of the services that you'll want to access are restricted to the US or UK or some other such region. You can bypass these restrictions if you manage to set up a VPN, which is really not that hard. Here's a simple step-by-step guide to setting it up.

Our first task was to find a VPN service that suited our needs. The best option we could find was Unlocator, but you can go with any other VPN that you're comfortable with as well. They offer a paid service for \$4.95 (₹299) a month which is quite competitive as far as VPN services go. Do

keep the following in mind when looking for a VPN service for yourself though:

1. Latency: This should be as low as possible to ensure that there is no lag when you're streaming content
2. Bandwidth: Certain VPN services restrict the bandwidth that's available to use, forcing you to experience a lot of buffering and slow downs, which can be painful. Most VPN services offer a trial period and you should make full use of that time to figure out if it's the right one for you.

Once you sign up, you will be provided with two DNS server IP addresses which you need to type into your router, if you have the option to edit your DHCP settings.

Configuring your router

- You need to figure out the pool of IP addresses available for use, this can be easily accessed via your router's settings menu. Many routers have a default range which starts from 192.168.1.100. From this pool pick an IP address that will be unique to your device (Fire TV, HTPC, etc.). Ensure that the following data is kept ready.



A melding of media centre and game console, technology at its best

- IP address
- Default Gateway address
- Subnet mask (Default - 255.255.255.0 or you'd have to calculate separately based on your IP by following this URL: <http://digit.in/SubnetCal>)
- Bit mask (Default value - 24)
- DNS address 1
- DNS address 2
- Find the advanced network settings on your router or other device. This will vary depending on your hardware.
- Start entering the data when you find the right screen. (Hint: It'll be the one asking you for the above information).
- Once you have entered the data, wait for a few seconds till the connection resolves itself
- Check if you can now access to your region-locked content.

An International account

Most streaming services and media stores such as Amazon and iTunes restrict access to their content to U.S. accounts. When creating one such account, you can usually get away with just an international address which you can find by simply opening Google Maps and picking a random location (even a McDonalds will do).

Some services might ask for a credit card, and getting one couldn't be simpler. Navigate to <https://www.entropay.com/> and